everyone would laugh. And then other times you'd think he was being funny, but in the meantime he was being dead serious.

Hansie would sometimes leave messages under your door to inform you that there would be a 6.30 a.m. team meeting and that you had to attend. Except, of course, no one would be there when you rocked up. And then sometimes he would crack a joke and you'd be rolling around laughing, and he would be like, 'What are you laughing at?' You didn't know what was potting half the time – whether you should smile or be upset. Hansie just had an aura about him, you know, a presence. But you could never tell whether he was being serious or not.

So Hansie makes the call that night, and you know me. Especially in those days, I was going to be at anything that resembled half a party. Despite being keen myself, the bottom line was that when Hansie made a call, his teammates bought into it.

We had a great time that night. We weren't misbehaving too badly, but plenty of beers and shooters were involved, and we got back to the hotel pretty late and quite drunk. I'm not entirely sure why Hansie had wanted to party on that specific night. Perhaps, because we had all batted badly, he wanted us to let off a little steam and indicate that we needn't worry too much about it. But I never got over the idea that the person he most wanted to reassure was me. After all, it had been the first time I had opened the Test batting, and I had failed badly in both innings.

Another reason why I thought this was because I was sharing a room with Hansie during that Test – it was one of the few times we would share a room. In those days, even though all the other players shared rooms, it was the team captain's privilege to have his own space. At that time I used to share with Paul Adams, but in PE, Hansie said, 'No, Hersch, you and I are going to share a room for a few nights.'

Given the match-fixing scandal we'd both become embroiled in two years later, you might think that a more sinister reason lay behind his invitation to share a room, but I can assure you nothing of the kind happened on that occasion. I think Hansie knew the pressure I felt as a 24-year-old opener, and he was offering me his guidance and support.

The following day, the five batsmen who were already out watched their teammates – including a hung-over Pat Symcox – add another 52 runs to the total before we were all out for 195. The following day the Proteas bowled the West Indies out for 141, to win the Test easily by 178 runs. In